

MIRKA MORA HAS A WALL

She's so excited she can't sleep

By KEITH DUNSTAN

UNQUESTIONABLY one of Melbourne's most enchanting creatures is Mirka Mora. God has passed a wand over her. She has never grown a day older since she was 14. Yes, at 57 there's a grey hair here and there is another over there but she still has brown eyes as big as cricket balls. Charles Blackman eyes really.

She has an almost gleeful smile and she still wears little girl dresses and little girl shoes. They are Alice shoes. Some call her the eternal gypsy but to me she is *Alice Through the Looking Glass*. She has that eternal air of innocence and wonder. The novelist Joyce Cary once created an artist named Gully Jimson. Inside Gully Jimson there was an irresistible force. He went berserk whenever he saw a bare wall. Walls had to be adorned, beautified, painted upon. Mirka Mora has a wall right now. She is so excited she cannot sleep at night. One thing calms her down. She adores expensive perfume; this makes her breathe deeply and helps her to doze. But as she lies in bed she is working images.

Perhaps Melbourne's most bizarre building is Flinders Street Railway Station. Robert Morley once said it looked as if they were setting out to design St Paul's and suddenly they got confused. Actually it is a cross between an Islamic temple and the Brighton Pavilion.

However, millions are being spent. The barriers have been swept away and now it has a Fab squeaky-clean look. Right on Flinders Street, just before you cross Princes Bridge, utterly prime position, there is a wall, nine metres by six. That's for Mirka.

She is filling it with fantastic figures. There are animals, fish with legs, a bunyip, a train... oh yes, there has to be a lovely train... There are faces taken live out of the street. BLF workers in their yellow helmets, a pink punk with her hair standing on end.

At the mural's lower level there are sculpted pictures. Children can feel them. There is one image of a child all bound up. "The child is strapped," says Mirka, "because children are not set free. They are a bit strangled. We do not listen to them enough."

The mural is in mosaic and her palette is a million tiny pieces of glass. Glass is a very unforgiving medium. So she has had to study geometry. She has studied the great mosaics of Italy dating back to

the fifth and sixth centuries. She has sketch plans where every piece has to go. The great murals were always done in plaster. Not here. There is too much train vibration at Flinders Street Station so every piece has to be stuck on.

She has the help of Bruno Fortuna, an Italian. Bruno has olive skin, a big smile and a big black moustache. "Isn't he beautiful," says Mirka. "He knows what to do. His family has been making mosaics for three generations. It is a joy to see him cut a mosaic. He caresses every piece."

Mirka is French and she rolls out her accent even better than Edith Piaf. She was born in Paris. Her mother was a Rumanian and her father Lithuanian. It is better to let her tell the story:

"They met in Paris. My mother was an artist of life. She was not well educated, she had a lot of imagination, tremendous spirit. My father loved books. He was an antique dealer. All my childhood I saw wondrous things. He used to collect knives. We had one wall that was a panoply of swords, all shapes, some curved. He loved to collect German armour, antique stuff which soldiers wore.

"When the Germans came to Paris, they went from house to house demanding all metals. My father wouldn't let them have it. As soon as it was night he threw all his armour, his swords, his priceless collection into the Seine. It is still there, somewhere near Notre Dame. Isn't that sad?

"We had beautiful furniture. My father loved Napoleon furniture, with a lot of encrustation. Very ornate, not unlike mosaics. Sometimes we would be very wealthy, sometimes everything was lost. The war years we did not do well.

"My father was Jewish. You had to wear a yellow star. I remember the first day. My mother didn't know what to do. When I went off to school she decorated my yellow star all around with lace. A policeman stopped me. Sent me home. 'What are you doing?' he said. I could have been arrested.

"The worst day was July 6, 1942. A policeman came to collect us at 11.30 am. He was a French policeman, very nice, he could see we were not ready and he announced he would come back at 1.30. My mother said to my father 'I will go with the children, you hide.'

"So my mother, with her three daughters went off to concentration camp. They put us in a train where they put all the animals. My mother had an envelope, paper and a pencil. She said to

me 'Madeleine'... you see, my name really is Madeleine. I prefer Mirka. It is the name of the yeti, the snowman; also a Tibetan name and it means maker of images. Isn't that lovely? My grandmother had that name...

"In the train, mother said, 'Madeleine, look through the wood and tell me which stations we pass and I'll write it down. Then you will know where we are.' That's what we did. When we finally slowed down she threw the envelope out of the train. It was addressed to my father, no stamp. A dog could have carried it off, anything. But some wonderful person picked it up and posted it. I think of that person every day.

"Anyway my father got the letter, he knew in which camp we were and after three weeks he got us out. I don't know how but he used some influence. Of the 25,000 people who went into that camp only 18 survived. I was 14 then. We were put in a horse cart and taken out. I saw all the people on the fence looking at us and I felt so ashamed that we left everybody behind."

A member of the Resistance who worked on a railway station got them false passports.

"Now Mirka was neither Mirka nor Madeleine. She was Mahdi, born in Tunisia. Individually, and alone, they all went to a secret hiding place in the country and they remained there until the war was over.

What happened then? She worked with orphans who had lost their parents during the war.

And she went to a theatre school. The great Jean Louis Barault was there. So too was Marcel Marceau.

"Marcel Marceau was my teacher. He knew me when I was 17, that's why we always see each other when he comes to Melbourne."

Then she met Georges Mora, who was to be her husband. "Georges used to deal with inventors and sold patents. Inventors are very like painters. So we married and came to Australia in 1951. We had a studio in 9 Collins Street. People such as Charles Blackman and Arthur Boyd used to come there. This was the very studio once occupied by Tom Roberts, a fabulous place. Streeton, Longstaff, they all came. We lived there for 15 years."

Mirka was always a painter. She took her paints when she went on her honeymoon and she did a painting from the first floor of their hotel in Annecy, a French village near Switzerland. She still